

Psychology & Questioning Techniques



Psychology & Questions:

- **Untrained questioning can be counter-productive**
- **Psychology is a useful tool available to insurers**
- **Staff can be trained to apply psychology through questioning techniques**



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The Purpose of Intelligent Questions

- Find the truth
- Obtain detail
- Work with the detail
- Make Intelligent decisions



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The Development of Psychology in Questioning

1983, Forensic Psychologist Dr. Eric Shepherd's *Conversation Management* interviewing model for Merseyside Police:

- **Greeting:** build empathy with interviewee
- **Explanation:** set out purpose and expectations of the interview to gather a broad and highly detailed account
- **Mutual Activities:** emphasise need for fine-grain detail and multiple accounts of the event from interviewee > interviewer to probe
- **Close:** summarise back to interviewee to agree detail provided.



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The Development of Psychology in Questioning

1984 psychologists Geiselman and Fisher's *Cognitive Interview technique emerged* seeks to enhance witness recollection by requiring the interviewee to recall the event in question from a variety of different physical and chronological perspectives:

- *Context reinstatement* – witness is required to form an image of environmental aspects of original scene; emotional reaction and feelings at time; physical conditions present.
- *Report everything* – including details witness might feel irrelevant.
- *Change perspective* – report from a variety of different perspectives
- *Reverse order* – start from different starting points
- Formed the basis of PEACE, the 1992 British police model



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Making Insurance Questions Intelligent:

Routine Claims Questionnaires:

1. Ensure that your questions are reasonable
2. What information you are seeking to obtain?
3. Why do you want to obtain it?
4. What you are going to do with the answer provided
5. If the answer to 4 above is nothing, then don't ask the question!



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Making Insurance Questions Intelligent:

Investigative Interview Questioning:

1. Create empathy
2. Explain what is going to happen and why
3. Obtain customer 'buy in' via agreement
4. Do not invite resistance
5. Do not give away useful information
6. Control the conversation
7. Use funnelling technique when appropriate
8. Deliver 'Hidden Messages'



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Hidden Messages

Hidden Messages

- Listen very carefully
- Confirm not tell
- We can easily validate
- Contact with other parties
- Our role is to help claimant to progress their claim – not settle it



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Biggest Obstacle to Obtaining Information

- **The Interviewer. Why?**
 - Biased agenda
 - Auto suggestion
 - Assumed perspective
 - Predictive displays
 - Poor listening skills
 - Asks wrong questions
 - Impatience



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So:

- Minimise the interviewer's involvement
- Concentrate on answers, not questions
- Statement dynamics outweigh story mechanics
- Do not show the fraudster where to lie by revealing valuable information
- Do not put words into the customer's mouth

Always Remember:

Fraudsters are not stupid!

Intelligent Questioning

Avoid Counter-Productive Questions

- A question that works against any element of the process
 - Confusion
 - Resistance
 - ‘Tainted’ answers
 - Partial answers
 - Too short an answer



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Avoid Counter-Productive Questions

Examples:

- Complex
- String
- Option
- Leading
- Interrupting



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Avoid Counter-Productive Questions

Interviewers who use these types of questions:

- Are auto suggestive
- Have an assumed perspective
- Are asking the wrong questions
- Are ineffective
- Will come to the wrong conclusion



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The Psychology of Truth & Lies

- Lying is not normal behaviour
- Abnormal brain activity is revealed in:
 - Non-Verbal Behaviour - body language
 - Verbal Behaviour – words and sounds
- Knowledge of these behaviours helps to assess risk & is greatly enhanced through skilled questioning.



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How Can We Use Psychology To Assess Risk?

- Understand how memory works
- Understand truthful behavioural indicators
- Understanding untruthful behavioural indicators
- Understand how this knowledge can focus questioning



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Understanding Memory

- Exercise
- Truth tellers effectively replay mind recordings of past events they can remember
- Easier to remember important / traumatic events than routine, non-important
- Liars have a vacuum in their imagination in which to create a picture



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